The Wrench Studios presents
THE ICEBOX
Written by Master Freeze

Issue #6: Loopstation, the Beatbox Instrument

In the world of beatboxing, innovation is always welcome. In order to appeal to a larger audience and invite more creativity, beatbox has been used in many ways. This includes acapella, remixes, competitions, talent performances, DJ sets, tutorials, ear-training, music theory, beatbox groups, and of course, beatbox battles.

While beatboxing itself is already niche, it has been experiencing a lot more growth, innovation, and exposure to mainstream since the start of the 2020s. Many artists have been carrying beatboxing to a new level and making it more accessible to the public audience, such as Wing and the Beatpella House.

Another aspect of the beatboxing community which has seen impressive growth in the last three years is the loopstation beatboxers. Loopstation is yet another niche performance-based community that was originally nested within the original beatbox community, but has since branched out into its own unique area of music production.

A loopstation device is an electronic device that records in real-time and loops recordings so that an artist can add layers or modulate their inputs. The device can be linked to electric guitars, basses, drums, grooveboxes, phones, computers, launchpads, mixers, speaker systems, and microphones.

In beatbox loopstation, the only inputs being made are entirely from the mouth. All of the drums, snares, basses, and melodies have to be sourced from an input originally done by the mouth. The inputted beatbox sounds can be electronically enhanced using various features on a loopstation device. When connected to a launchpad or modulator, sounds can be maximized and effects can greatly change the composition of an inputted beatbox pattern.

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A loopstation artist must create tracks by experimenting with all of the options on their singular or multiple devices. Certain beatbox sounds can be enhanced with specific effects to produce certain loopstation sounds. Different patterns can be enhanced, or the type of effects can be used in a specific order to result in particular loopstation sounds. Some artists also run memories through their loopstation device to start a sequence that they can activate at any time. A successful loopstation track takes into account all of the dynamics of the device to produce a full song. The neat part is that a loopstation song is always performed in real-time, which means there is risk of making a mistake and ruining the entire track. This does, in fact, mean that a loopstation artist has to memorize the entire process of creating a specific track!

When beatbox loopstation started, everyone was using the early generations of BOSS devices, with BOSS RC-505 being the most commonly used device. These devices featured anywhere between 2-5 input tracks and very limited modulation options compared to modern devices. Some of the older loopstations also had pedals because they were designed specifically for guitar artists.

During this time, beatbox loopstation was quite simple. A beatboxer could input organic beatboxing into the device and layer it to create a full track. The tracks produced this way were easy to follow and sounded very human. It was essentially a more accessible way to create music with the mouth without having to worry about layers that would be physically impossible to accomplish with regular beatboxing.

Swissbeatbox, the largest beatbox organization in the world and founder of Grand Beatbox Battle, introduced a beatbox loopstation category in 2013. It is thanks to this change that loopstation became more common in beatboxing, to the point that loopstation companies started to design devices specifically for beatboxers. This is what separated guitarist features and introduced extra devices so the loopstation could become more dynamic for different artists.

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Over the next six years, the loopstation category introduced more and more acceptable devices and “exploitations” that really changed the essence of the category. Additional devices included a Helix effect processor, launchpad, and devices with different pads and external synths or effect libraries. The “exploitations” did not become relevant until a bit later.

With all of these new devices allowed, the loopstation category transformed from organic beatboxing to music production mania. By the time GBB2019 rolled around, artists were creating dubstep, riddim, techno, psytrance, and many other genres using the loopstation and secondary devices. It was clear that the category had fundamentally changed and classic looping was outdated.

Beatboxers and fans expressed their concerns regarding the state of the loopstation category to the point that, in GBB2023, secondary devices were banned. To account for the artists who wanted to produce music, a new category was introduced called “producer” which had no restrictions on what devices and samples could be used. The loopstation category then became a one-device, eight-person bracket. The only exception was the launchpad, which requires a loopstation to input recorded sounds and enhance them in a more user-friendly format.

In GBB23 and GBB24, the loopstation category consisted of just two primary devices: BOSS RC-505 MKII and a desired Novation Launchpad model. There are yet more key distinctions to make after the producer category was introduced. The MKII is the second edition to the BOSS loopstation that was used years ago for organic beatbox-based looping. This new version has much more potential and can be used organically or electronically. I will return to this point later.

In GBB23 and GBB24, the loopers who chose to only use the loopstation without the launchpad were the ones who had the most success. Not only did they advance in the bracket, but the audience reception of them was generally greater because their looping was easier to follow and felt more like actual live-looping.

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For example, in GBB24, every quarterfinal had at least one artist using both a loopstation and a launchpad, but none of them advanced to the semi-finals except for Raje, who was battling another launchpad user, Duncan. Raje then lost the semi-finals in a very close battle to Yaswede, who went on to become the champion after winning against another loopstation-only artist, Matej.

At the time, people agreed that Raje's style was crazy and innovative, but many were unsure how to feel about his looping style. Raje inputted his sounds into a loopstation, modulated them, and inputted them into his launchpad to unlock insane potential for his sounds. He then sequenced all of his unique sounds to create a track that plays almost entirely automatically. This was viewed negatively by loopers as it did not feel like a live-performance, and many accused Raje of prerecording his tracks.

This new style of looping was thanks to "exploitation" as I had mentioned before. Basically, the BOSS MKII has more potential due to its features for sequencing, saving multiple memories, and increasing the number of sound effects based on cable technique. Yes, even the way the cables are plugged into the device have a huge effect!

In recent years, it has become the standard to use the loopstation with as many exploits as possible. Thus, in GBB25 and GBB26, only the BOSS MKII or inferior, single-loopstation setups were allowed in competition.

From the changes beginning in 2023 until now, there is one artist from Japan named Mahiro. He is my absolute favorite loopstation artist, but he profits from exploiting the BOSS MKII device. He only needs to input a bass, snare, and kick at the beginning of his rounds and is able to produce an entire track from there. Mahiro's style of looping involves dubstep, riddim, and a little bit of Japanese-techno elements. His style is still more organic than Raje or Duncan, who borderline abuse the memory system and sequencing all of their tracks.

Still, Mahiro is able to turn a simple sigh into a full pattern of electronic basses and a couple of poorly inputted snares into an artificial drumbeat. In GBB25, his tracks followed a motif of riddim drops, crystal-clear snares designed to set a theme, very intense drops that did not require live-looping, and extremely impressive sound design. For example, his track “Megalodon VIP” features water droplet sounds, a buzz-spring, and even a sonar ambience. His tracks “Renegade” and “Goliath” both feature heavy riddim drops and choirs that he designs in real-time. Even though a lot of his methods for using the loopstation are not organic, he knew how to create a balance when necessary and achieved 3rd place in GBB25. This was very different from GBB26 where it was clear that he had adopted a more no-hands experience like Raje in 2024, who had also returned to the stage and won against Mahiro in the finals this year.

The producer category was ended after 2025, but the loopstation category still remains as a one-device policy. The BOSS MKII is about the most advanced loopstation device, so all other single-device setups are also permitted. For example, Tioneb is a French looper from the early era who returned in 2026 with the BOSS RC202, a two-track loopstation with significantly less capability. In 2025, Yaswede made a classic-track on the RC505 to commentate on how looping has evolved to the point where it's almost not even considered beatboxing anymore. He also has electronic elements in his tracks, but his reasoning was for the competition more than pushing the category forward.

Many people feel that the current loopstation category should again be referred to as a producer category, and the classic-style of looping should make a return. However, as artists are adapting and loopstation is getting more popular, this might not be the right move to make for the general audience.

Personally, I enjoy Mahiro and Raje, but I also understand how the classic-loopers must feel. I think it’s time to accept that the new age of looping will be as it is now. I agree with Swissbeatbox’s decision to reduce the category to just one device. I also believe that live-looping criteria for judges should be made more clear. Either way, I look forward to seeing what my favorite looper, Mahiro, can come up with next.

Maybe one day I will purchase a loopstation of my own…